entirety, in letter as much as in spirit. Cherry-picking individual provisions are hardly likely to advance the objective of finding common ground.

Where the border areas are concerned, the LAC must be strictly observed and respected; any attempt to unilaterally change the status quo cannot be countenanced. We cannot be in denial that peace and tranquillity in the border areas is the foundational basis for development of relations in other domains. If they are disturbed, so inevitably will the rest of the relationship. This is quite apart from the issue of progress in the boundary negotiations that are being separately held. Attempts to conflate one for the other will inevitably be seen through; it will never obfuscate the problems created by the developments of 2020.

While both nations are committed to a multipolar world, there should be an acceptance that a multipolar Asia is one of its essential constituents. Obviously, each nation will have its own interests, concerns and priorities, but sensitivity to them has to be shown by both sides. At the end of the day, relationships between major states are reciprocal in nature. As rising powers, each will have their own set of aspirations and their pursuit too cannot be ignored. There will always be divergences and differences but their management is essential to our ties. And finally, civilizational states like India and China must always take the long view. Departures from these axioms, as we witnessed in 2020, have serious implications.

For a variety of reasons, it is common for the Chinese to speak today of ‘international relations in the new era’. There is much that this terminology signifies, as is often the case with them. Whether we agree or not, what is undeniable is that the world order has now entered a very different phase from how it was envisaged after 1945. Without exaggeration, the rise of China is the most profound change in global politics since that of the US and the USSR after the Second World War. It has not just implications and lessons but significant policy consequences, especially for neighbours. India, therefore, would also do well to regard its own relationship with China as also having entered a new era. If there were any doubts on this score, the changed Chinese posture in the border areas has demonstrated that graphically. India is historically used to thinking of a Chinese presence to its north. For the last two decades, China is also rapidly growing as a maritime power, and we will also have to anticipate activities in the south.

Since there is so much flux underway, this might also be an opportune moment to reflect on how China and India have approached each other